



LINUX (WINDOWS REPLACEMENT)

Xandros' installation procedure is very simple. There are two modes of install, Express and Custom. Express install does not allow partitioning of the hard drive, but preserves existing Windows partitions. Custom install lets the user partition the hard drive.

After logging in for the first time, a First Run wizard allows the user to configure the network, printers, etc., in a very intuitive fashion. Sharing files on a Windows network is also very easy. There is also a facility for searching other computers on the network.

The Xandros desktop is essentially a variant of the K desktop Environment (KDE). In fact, many of the tools available via the Launch menu are standard KDE tools. For example, the Process Manager runs the kpm tool.

Clicking the Windows key on the keyboard brings up the Launch menu—such improvements make the user much more comfortable with the GUI. Xandros is considerably faster than the other distributions. It even supports active user switching, just like Windows XP.

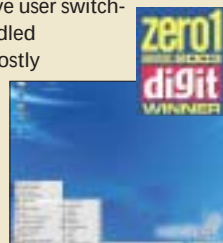
Xandros 1.0

- + Easy installation and configuration, Windows key on the keyboard brings up the Launch menu, active user switching, Crossover bundled
- Per-seat license costly

Price: \$99

Website:
www.xandros.com

Reviewed In:
August 2003



PREVIOUS WINNERS

2002: Mandrake Linux 8.2
2001: SuSE Linux 7.2 Professional

The Launch menu is very user-friendly, and similar to the Windows Start Menu. All the applications are neatly classified and arranged under specific categories so that the user does not have to remember command names.

The per-seat license can get a bit heavy on the pocket. Otherwise, the only fault we found with the distribution we got was

WORTHY MENTIONS

ELX Linux Power Desktop 2.0

- + Launchpads provide easy access to groups of similar applications, Windows-style icons, accessing Windows shares is extremely easy, free for personal and educational use
- Works well with KDE, but not with Gnome

Price: Free for personal and educational use, \$50

Website: www.elxlinux.com
Reviewed In: August 2003

Lycoris Desktop/LX

- + Fast installation, guided tour, near-perfect Windows desktop look and feel
- Hardware incompatibility could bring down the installation utility, worst hardware support amongst all the distributions

Price: \$40

Website: www.lycoris.com
Reviewed In: August 2003

that Crossover was bundled—which brought the price up. Xandros now offers a distribution without a Windows emulator, which is obviously cheaper.

OPTICAL CHARACTER RECOGNITION

If the question of why one might need OCR software comes up—just use your imagination. You could scan newspaper articles and save them on your hard disk as a searchable library. All those business faxes could go neatly into a folder. What about those ancient dot-matrix printouts you can't afford to throw away because you might need them some time? OCR and de-paper them.

The best thing about FineReader is its sheer versatility about file formats or the kinds of document it can recognise.

The way FineReader scanned the newspaper clip in our tests was awe-inspiring. Every bit of the layout and formatting, all the fonts and images—just about everything was retained. The resulting file looked just like the original newspaper clip—only, it consisted of clickable text!

FineReader has wizards all over the place—right from a scanner wizard to a 'Save' wizard. The main screen is well-laid out, with four buttons—Open, Read, Spell-check and Save. Each of these has drop-down lists with options. If you want

ABBYY FineReader Professional 6.0

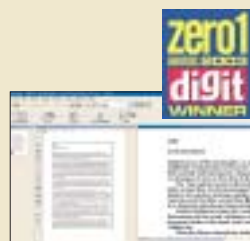
- + Extremely accurate scanning, extreme versatility, lots of wizards, several output formats, works in background
- None

Price:

Rs 13,800

Web site:
www.netspiderindia.com

Reviewed In:
October 2003



PREVIOUS WINNERS

2002: ABBY FineReader 6.0 CE
2001: Fine Reader 5.0 Pro

to, you can use the default options and let FineReader do everything for you.

Features-wise, FineReader is packed to the brim. The number of options in the spell-check rivals those available in Microsoft Word. Customising almost everything is a breeze. There's also a pattern editor that enables you to customise

WORTHY MENTIONS

OmniPage Pro 12

- + Recognises PDF documents, comprehensive post-OCR text editor, OCR proofreader
- Scanning weak in complex images

Price: Rs 27,600

Web site: www.hclinfosystems.com
Reviewed In: October 2003

Readiris Pro 8

- + A wide range of input as well as output supported, learning capability
- Weak in scanning from newspaper or magazine clips

Price: Rs 18,492

Web site: www.irislink.com
Reviewed In: October 2003

FineReader to suit your particular documents, with their particular special characters or formats.

With FineReader, you've reached the end of the road as far as OCRing is concerned—you won't need anything else.